



DAVID SHAW
JANUARY 20TH, 2023



MICHAEL CIMARUSTI

Co-owner and Chef



PROVIDENCE TASTING MENU

QUARTET OF AMUSE BOUCHES

TAI SNAPPER TARTARE

Chives, lemon, and black truffle

STEELHEAD TROUT

In house smoked steelhead trout, lemon cream, horseradish, pickled and marinated beet

WAGYU TARTARE

Wagyu from Oita, oyster cracker, oyster aioli, and black ink lime purée

UNI CRACKER

Pickled jicama, pickled kombu, uni butter.

AHUALOA FARMS MACADAMIA

Golden kaluga caviar, caramelized shallot, nori powder, tapioca pearl, macadamia nut and its foam

JAPANESE HIRAMASA SASHIMI

Seven-day dry aged Hiramasa from Nagasaki, celtuce, satsuma, shiso blossom, chrysanthemum, satsuma gel, and Casa Migmag olive oil

UNI EGG

Sea urchin from Santa Barbara, champagne beurre blanc, and brioche crouton

WARM FRICASSEE OF SHELLFISH

Big island abalone, giant clam, geoduck, uni, pistachio in two textures

NANCY'S DOWN EAST SEA SCALLOP

Leek fondue, black truffle from France, emulsified butter, and scallop tea

NEW ZEALAND JOHN DORY

John Dory stuffed with lobster mousseline, jus de crustacés, Californian golden chanterelle mushroom, snap peas

COLUMBIA RIVER STEELHEAD

Sprouting cauliflower, meyer lemon, steelhead roe, fumée sauce with butter and basil oil

APPLE, VERBENA SENCHA, BUDDHA'S HAND

Apple mint chip, green apple sorbet, verbena sencha granita, candied Buddha's hand, and sencha powder

HOUSE-MADE ECUADORIAN CHOCOLATE

Gianduja hazelnut chocolate cube with cream praline, buckwheat gelato, chocolate tuile, and chocolate espresso sauce

MIGNARDISE & TEA

Salted caramel tart with vanilla bourbon cream

Persimmon yuzu jelly

Sicilian pistachio macaron

White sesame dark chocolate

Cocoa mint tea with honey

FAREWELL GIFT

House made granola



With a glass of Dönnhoff Tonschiefer riesling trocken from Nahe, my degustation journey at Providence unfolds on a quartet of amuse bouches. The first bite is a tartlet that features Japanese tai snapper. Carrying a refreshing umami, the flesh is further engulfed in a mesmerizing sweet sour vinaigrette of chives and lemon with a hint of black truffle. As a final touch to the whole, a piece of marinated black truffle is placed to cap the tartlet. The ensuing bite deviates from freshness and ushers in a darker flavor profile. Inside the mini cylinder rests the minced smoked steelhead salmon mixed with lemon cream and horseradish. The spiciness of the horseradish mingles perfectly with the smokiness of the salmon, which is further accented with the rich flavors of pickled and marinated beet. Next up is a rare beef course in this seafood-dominating restaurant. Using premium wagyu from Oita, the oyster cracker is dotted with white and black purée of oyster aioli and black ink lime purée. The final amuse bouche arrives separately on the table. Featuring uni from local California bays, the uni cracker consists of pickled jícama, pickled kombu, and uni butter. All of the amuse-bouches are fine on their own, yet the cracker being the mutual component makes the mini bites journey somehow dull in the end.





Nestling in the gorgeous Jaune de Chrome Blue Impression plate bowl by JL Coquet, the next course blows my mind as one of the most elegant and harmonious yet the most innovative caviar courses I have tasted. At the center of the plate rests a light cloud of Hawaiian Ahualoa farms macadamia foam embedded with caramelized shallot, macadamia nuts, and tapioca pearls. The medley is paired with a quenelle of the most luxurious golden Kaluga caviar, then showered by a rain of nori powder. When everything is mixed well and sent to the tongue, a turbulence of oceanic umami burst out from each cell of the caviar mingles with the cascade of the nutty warmth of the macadamia that jointly radiates infinite waves of oomph. This is a well composed dish showcasing a perfect equilibrium of flavors. The only problem being that the texture of the macadamia nuts in the foam, which overwhelms the delicacy of the caviar, the foam, and the tapioca pearl.



Following the splendid caviar opening dish is a sashimi dish with a heavy Japanese mark, which centers on a core of Nagasaki Hiramasa sashimi surrounded by hemispheres of celtuce and satsuma orange. Rests on top of a piece of satsuma gel, the whole is further accented with chrysanthemum and shiso blossom and finished with a drizzle of Casa Migmag olive oil. All of the paired goods are light and refreshing on their own yet strong enough to cover the pristine umami of the fish. What a mournful creation that wastes the fragile delicacy not only carried by the fish per se but also gained through the seven-day dry aging process.

With an extra thirty-five bucks, I get to taste the most iconic course of Providence that has been on the menu ever since the restaurant's first dinner service. Consisting of sea urchin from Santa Barbara, champagne beurre blanc, and brioche crouton, this is another classical dish featuring the great combination of uni and egg. Unlike most restaurants that fancy the Japanese egg version of chawanmushi topped with uni, the egg here is almost in its original form as a barely poached egg, resulting in a yolk that functions as a creamy sauce that holds everything together. The champagne beurre blanc bestows another layer of buttery creaminess as well as a brightly refreshing acidity on the melange, whereas the crouton counters the whole with its crispiness. It is fairly strange for me to see this course making its appearance after two courses rather than at the beginning as expected.





Continuing with the warm charm of seafood, a rich scallop dish starring premium scallop from Maine arrives on the table. Butter basted to a perfect stage, the scallop is gorgeously caramelized on the surface while its inner flesh is still succulent and tender, allowing the satisfyingly giant scallop to evoke an untamed yet mellow sweetness equivalent to what one could expect from a premium Hokkaido scallop. The scallop is then drenched in a rich bath of emulsified butter, leek fondue, French black truffle, and scallop tea made by dehydrating and then rehydrating the leftover scallop parts. Enriched by the depth of the butter bath, the scallop underscored by leek and black truffle is thus able to reveal multidimensional umami and richness.

Ensuing the egg uni course is a warm fricassee in a similar manner. As the first main warm dish of the night, the dish carries a hot spring of seafood medley fricassee, including Big Island abalone and geoduck, that divulges a mesmerizing creamy umami with complexity and depth. The rich foam and potage center on a uni island featuring giant Santa Barbara uni that oozes unparalleled tropical fruity sweetness. Two textures of pistachio are then added as a final touch to the dish, introducing another layer of nutty flavor that sings in perfect harmony with the crustaceans. My only regret is the texture of the poached pistachio. Evoking an unpleasant soggy texture, the purpose of its appearance is yet a myth.





Moving on to the first fish dish of the night we have a John Dory dish. Sourcing from New Zealand, the dish is centered on a “sandwich” of John Dory fillet stuffed with lobster mousseline, which is further paired with Californian golden chanterelle mushroom and snap peas, then finished with a jus de crustaces.

The lobster mousseline lying at the center is so heavy both texturally and flavorfully in a way that not only makes the dish taste like a meat course but also greatly overshadows the John Dory flesh. To

finish the dish, the rather light-textured jus de crustaces carries a yet overwhelmingly heavy flavor, adding another burden for one's palate.

For the finale of the savory part, diners have the liberty to choose one course among a seafood dish, a duck course, or a wagyu course with a supplement. As a quasi-pescatarian, I go with the seafood course chef

Cimarusti is best known for without hesitation. The final course is rather a classical steelhead trout dish with a traditional flavor profile. A medallion

of warmly cooked steelhead trout engulfed in a rich fumée sauce of butter and basil oil is paired with sprouting cauliflower and its purée, a layer of steelhead trout roe, as well as some Meyer lemon. It is not obscure for one

to observe the Japanese hint in chef Cimarusti’s dishes, and this one has a particularly clear mark of another Japanese influence. The combination of fish and its own roe is quite famous in Japanese cuisine, not only because

of the bonus flavor it could present but also because of the “parent and child” meaning of the combination. The steelhead roe here definitely divulges a gorgeous smoky tone to the whole, which is further accented with the smoky fumée sauce that accumulatively lingers on the palate to underline the flesh. While both the roe and the sauce provide depth and richness to the whole, basil oil and sprouting cauliflower are introduced to

counter the whole with hints of freshness.





After a series of seafood courses, I'm finally taking a break by enjoying a palate cleanser pre-dessert. In this course, everything hides under a piece of dehydrated and candied apple mint chip dusted with sencha powder. Upon cracking the chip, the remaining components reveal themselves: a quenelle of green apple sorbet on top of some verbena sencha granita and candied Buddha's hand. What's magic about the composition is how it could reveal multidimensional texture and flavor and ephemeral lightness at the same time. Cleaned by the light breeze from the palate-cleanser, the palate is ready for the main dessert course. In the main dessert course, the acclaimed Gianduja is showcased as a chocolate mousse cube filled with cream praline. On top of the cube is a quenelle of buckwheat gelato and a crispy chocolate tuile, with an additional small drop of the chocolate espresso sauce on the side. The dish reveals shades of mellow chocolate flavor sublimated by a trilogy of buckwheat, hazelnut, and espresso. The mousse cube per se displays a light velvety texture and nutty richness further elevated by both the coolness and the buckwheat flavor from the gelato. The chocolate tuile then underscores the whole with an extra crunchiness, leaving space for the final touch of espresso sauce to cut through the whole composition.



While chef Cimarusti is generous with his main dishes, it is without surprise that a grand feast of petit fours is also offered at the end of the meal. On another JL Coquet plate presents four pieces of mignardise, uncovering a wide range of flavors from refreshing persimmon yuzu jelly and bright nutty scallion pistachio macaron to rich boozy salted caramel tart with vanilla bourbon cream and toasty white sesame dark chocolate. To elevate the experience, a cup of cocoa honey herbal tea is offered alongside.

